

Vartika Shukla, *57*
Chairman & Managing Director, Engineers India Ltd

RAJWANT RAWAT

GOAL POST

"Everyone needs to formulate a long-term strategy for their profession. Equally important is the need to step out of your comfort zone"

CHECKLIST FOR THE SORORITY "Be financially independent. Ensure you remain in your career and deploy whatever resources are necessary, even at some expense"

Engineering Excellence

FOR VARTIKA SHUKLA, EXCELLENCE is not an exception but a rule—which she has been following for the past 35 years. It's evident in her career trajectory. The chairperson and managing director (CMD) of Engineers India Ltd (EIL), who commenced her professional journey with the state-run engineering consultancy firm as a management trainee way back in 1988, eventually rose to the helm of leadership in 2021.

A Chemical Engineering graduate from IIT Kanpur, Vartika hails from a family of engineers, educationists and lawyers in Lucknow. She says she has stayed the course till today at the company due to the exposure, the wide variety of professional challenges and the immense learning opportunities. "The company enabled me to grow along with the growth in the sector," she says. She notes that the projects EIL works on have become more complex and mammoth in nature and scale, and "the rapid technological changes in the oil and gas sector have kept me excited all along".

Since taking over as CMD, Vartika has expanded EIL's portfolio beyond oil and gas, diversifying into newer areas such as renewable energy, 2G ethanol and sustainable aviation fuel, among others. The company is executing India's first bio-refinery project for Assam Bio Refinery that uses bamboo-based feedstock for the production of fuel-grade ethanol. Infrastructure is another sector that EIL is trying to make inroads into. "We already have a very good order book in the sector, especially in projects related to reducing the energy footprint in buildings and constructing of world-class quality data centres," she says.

Geographical outreach—especially in South Africa, South America and the Middle East—is another pillar of EIL's growth strategy. "I'm a firm believer of the idea that we have a lot to contribute on the international front," says Vartika. Under her watch, overseas business grew exponentially to over Rs 600 crore in FY23 as against Rs 36 crore the previous year.

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Under her, EIL has expanded into newer areas such as renewable energy, 2G ethanol and sustainable aviation fuel, among others, besides spreading its global footprint

In the realm of innovation, Vartika is the co-inventor of over 30 patents spanning proprietary hardware, process design and futuristic energy technologies. In her previous role, she spearheaded the R&D and process design team. "We are one organisation where 60 per cent of our patents are commercialised, which is very rare because usually most of the patents come from fundamental research," she says. To improve the firm's performance, she has initiated the implementation of Quality Circle and Six Sigma approaches—a rarity in engineering consultancy. It's this very blend of excellence and leadership that makes Vartika perfect for occupancy at the very top. ■

–Sonal Khetarpal